

Module 04: Cognition — The Thinking Cap

Learning Objectives

1. Understand what **Cognition** is (thinking and guessing).
2. Learn that your brain is like a **Prediction Machine**.
3. See how thinking helps us know what to do.

Introduction: The Thinking Cap

Imagine you have a magical invisible hat called a **Thinking Cap**. When you wear it, you can figure out puzzles!

One day, Sally put on her Thinking Cap. She saw heavy grey clouds in the sky (that was her **Perception**).

Her Thinking Cap started buzzing. *Buzz, buzz, buzz.* "Hmm," thought Sally. "Grey clouds usually mean... RAIN!"

Sally made a **Prediction**. She guessed it would rain. So she put on her yellow raincoat.

Ten minutes later... *Drip, drop, splash!* It rained! Sally stayed dry because her brain helped her guess what would happen next.

Key Concepts

1. What is Cognition?

Cognition is a fancy word for **Thinking**. It's what happens inside your head.

- Perception is the news coming IN (Eyes see clouds).
- Cognition is figuring out what the news MEANS (Clouds = Rain).

2. The Prediction Machine

Your brain is the best machine in the world. It is always asking: *"What will happen next?"*

- If you drop a ball, your brain guesses it will fall **down**.
- If you smell cookies baking, your brain guesses they will taste **yummy**.
- If you see a dog wagging its tail, your brain guesses it is **friendly**.

3. Maps in Your Head

Your brain keeps a map of the world. It knows where your house is, what your mom looks like, and that fire is hot. You use this map to make your guesses. When you learn something new, you update your map!

Activities

Activity 1: What Comes Next?

I will start a pattern. You guess what comes next!

- Red, Blue, Red, Blue, Red... (Blue!)
- Clap, Stomp, Clap, Stomp... (Clap!)
- Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday... (Thursday!)

Activity 2: The Magic Box Guess

Shake a gift box.

- Does it rattle? (Maybe LEGOs!)
- Is it soft and quiet? (Maybe a Teddy Bear!) Use your Thinking Cap to guess what's inside.

Summary

Cognition is how your brain thinks and makes guesses. It uses what you see and hear to predict what will happen next. This helps you stay safe, dry, and happy!

References

- *It Looked Like Spilt Milk* by Charles G. Shaw (A book about guessing shapes!)
- *Thinking, Fast and Slow* (Just kidding! That's for grown-ups. Read *The Boy Who Cried Wolf* instead—it's about bad predictions!)